

Title

Impact of structured palliative care education on end-of-life symptom recognition and management in nursing home populations

Abstract

Background: End-of-life care quality in residential facilities varies, partly due to variable recognition of palliative needs. This cluster-randomized study evaluated whether staff training in palliative care principles improves symptom identification and management at end of life. **Methods:** Ten nursing homes (5 intervention, 5 control) participated. Intervention sites provided staff with a 40-hour palliative care qualification course. Primary outcomes included documentation of palliative symptoms and corresponding interventions in resident records during the final three months of life. Data were extracted from medical records of 119 deceased residents (42 intervention, 77 control). **Results:** Specialized palliative consultation was documented for 19.0% of intervention residents versus 9.1% of control residents. Pain documentation rates were 57.1% versus 49.4% respectively. Of documented pain events, appropriate management was recorded in 73.6% of intervention cases versus 61.9% of control cases, with intervention residents showing significantly higher likelihood of receiving documented pain intervention (odds ratio 1.80; $p < 0.05$). **Conclusions:** Staff training in palliative principles improves end-of-life care quality through better symptom recognition and appropriate management documentation in nursing home settings.